

The Dharma Categories of the Dhāraṇī Called 'The Noble Heart of the Buddha'

Ārya-buddha-hṛdaya-nāma-dhāraṇī-dharma-viparyāya · Toh 514 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་སངས་རུ་མཆོག་གི་སྤྱི་པ་ཞེས་བུ་བྱའ་གི་ཟུང་སྐུ་གྱི་རྒྱ་གདངས།

Toh 514 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-buddha-hṛdaya-nāma-dhāraṇī-dharma-viparyāya and in Tibetan as the Phakpa Sangyé kyi Nyingpo zhé byawé Zung kyi Chö kyi Namgrang, rendered into English as "The Dharma Categories of the Dhāraṇī Called 'The Noble Heart of the Buddha.'" As its title indicates, the text belongs to the dhāraṇī literature of the Kangyur, presenting a classification or enumeration of Dharma teachings organized around a sacred dhāraṇī associated with the heart or essence of the Buddha. The work opens in the familiar sūtra style, with the Buddha present in a wondrous assembly of vast numbers of bodhisattvas at an extraordinary sacred site, suggesting that the dhāraṇī and its accompanying doctrinal categories are revealed within a visionary and ceremonially elevated setting. Sitting among the dhāraṇī collections of the Kangyur, this text reflects the broader tradition of canonical works that combine liturgical or mantra-based practice with systematic Dharma exposition.

In the language of India:
Ārya-buddha-hṛdaya-nāma-dhāraṇī-dharma-viparyāya. In the language of Tibet: The Dharma Categories of the Dhāraṇī Called "The Noble Heart of the Buddha."

I bow down to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was present within the sphere of the Tathāgata's activity — a classification of Dharma — in the courtyard of the assembly of the Precious Hermitage Arrayed, a place where wisdom is thoroughly analyzed, blessed by the buddhas of the past, universally praised by all sentient beings, the abode of great bodhisattvas, endowed with supreme excellence in every aspect, and practiced in accordance with the sameness of all phenomena. Amid the entirely luminous pavilion, surrounded on all sides by many tens of billions of bodhisattvas — every one of them prophesied from their various world systems, every one of them assembled from their various world systems, every one of them sons of the Tathāgata the Dharma King, and every one of them accomplished in the various dhāraṇīs and meditative absorptions (samādhis) — all facing inward and seated together, he

taught the Dharma.

Then the Blessed One declared to the vast bodhisattva assembly: "Sons of good family, for the benefit of the many, for the happiness of the many, out of compassion for the world, and for the welfare, benefit, and happiness of gods and of the many ordinary human beings — there exists a teaching called the Dharma Categories of the Dhāraṇī of the Heart of the Buddha, spoken by Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas as many in number as the grains of sand in the Ganges River.

"Whatever son or daughter of good family may bear this Dharma Categories of the Dhāraṇī called the Heart of the Buddha, or hold it, or recite it, or master it fully, or teach it extensively and correctly to others, or have faith in it, or be devoted to it with heightened aspiration — that person shall become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. They shall become inseparable from the retention of all phenomena. They shall become inseparable from the buddha Blessed Ones. They shall become inseparable from beholding and paying homage to Tathāgatas. They shall become inseparable from hearing the Dharma. They shall become inseparable from serving the Saṅgha. For a thousand eons they shall cross back over the ocean of saṃsāric existence. Until they attain perfect and complete awakening — unsurpassed, perfect, and complete — they shall recall their past lives. Swiftly they shall attain perfect and complete awakening — unsurpassed, perfect, and complete. They shall be protected by all hosts of spirits. Gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas (scent-eaters), asuras, garuḍas (sky-soaring eagles), kinnaras (half-human beings), great serpents, and all humans and non-humans shall rejoice. No disease shall find footing in their body. They shall not meet death at an untimely hour through harm inflicted by another. They shall not meet death by punishment, by the sword, or by poison. The evil māra shall find no opportunity against them. The gods of Māra's ranks shall find no opening against them — and in whatever place they are mindfully turned to, all those gods of Māra's ranks shall tremble, be terrified, be overwhelmed with fear, and flee in the ten directions.

"These, then, are the words of the Buddha. They are the great words of the Buddha. They are the great words authorized by the Buddha. They are the words of all buddhas. They are the words of all Tathāgatas."

Tadyathā: buddhe su-buddhe mahā-buddhe iha-buddhe tatra-buddhe buddhe buddhe buddhe buddhe-mati-buddhe sarva-buddha anumate sarva-buddhe

anujñānate buddha buddha.

Buddha. Buddha. Buddha. Buddha. Buddha. Buddha. Buddha. Buddha. The domain of buddhahood is boundless, and the teachings of the Dharma are boundless as well — yet in brief, the single thing to hold in mind is simply this: to cultivate the Dharma. This dhāraṇī was spoken by all buddhas out of love and compassion for sentient beings. It is the mudrā, the seal, of all phenomena.

Tadyathā: śuddhe su-śuddhe su-śuddhe śodhani saṃśodhani saṃśodhani
nirma-le mala apaga-te gate samāti-krānti krame sa-sama-sare sarā-sara-pare
aśoke viśoka śoka-śamani śānte upaśānte praśānte avabhāse sarva-puṇye
parimaṇḍite sarva-dharma-pratimaṇḍite hara hara mala hara cara cara
saṃcara cala cala saṃcala tala tala matala samatala riṇe riṇe suriṇe samariṇe
riṇa-mati loka-dhare loka-dhāriṇe dhara dhara ḍara ḍara rodha rodha
mahā-vijaya vāhini hana hana sarva-buddhe hrī-phreśi-trasi sarva-jñāpathe
sarva-jñāparamite mahā-pratibhāna sampanne samanta āloke buddhe viṣaye
buddha pratimaṇḍite bhagavate sara sara prasara prasara visara visara
prasara sarva-śoka apagate svāhā.

The moment the Blessed One had set forth this exposition of the Dharma, this enumeration of categories of the dhāraṇī of the heart-essence of the buddhas, the earth together with its mountains and forests shook in six ways. The great world-system of the trichiliocosm shook, shook greatly, and shook in every direction. The great ocean was stirred, stirred greatly, and stirred utterly throughout. The king of mountains, Mount Meru, trembled and quaked. All the abodes of Māra were struck with terror, and the gods of Māra's ranks together with the evil māras were seized with acute suffering and distress of mind, and were utterly overwhelmed.

Those sentient beings who witnessed the great earth shaking proclaimed three times aloud, again and again: "Homage to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha! Homage to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha!"

Those gods who had sincere faith in the Buddha scattered divine blossoms — māṇḍārava flowers and great māṇḍārava flowers — over the Blessed One. And all those who had taken refuge in the Buddha were filled with great joy.

And these words were spoken:

The lion of the Śākyas, perfected and complete —
in but a single instant the Protector, the Buddha,
proclaimed this dhāraṇī, the very heart-essence
of all the buddhas, in supreme exposition.

In that single instant the earth shook in six ways,
the ocean was stirred, and every abode of Māra
shook and trembled — and the gods of Māra's ranks
were seized with fright and thrown into confusion.
Māra was overcome with suffering and grief and woe.

Then the gods, hearing this with great wonder,
in order to make offerings to the Protector of the World,
hovered in the sky and scattered māṇḍāra blossoms.
Those who had faith in the Buddha, and others too,
offered necklaces and garlands, incense,
powders, ointments, garments, ornaments, and armlets.

These eight things shall become the adornment of its merits and benefits.

What are these eight? They are as follows: the adornment of not forgetting the
awakening mind; the adornment of searching out all learning without ever
being satisfied; the adornment of determining the profound Dharma through
dependent origination; the adornment of knowing the superior and inferior
faculties of all sentient beings; the adornment of examining and analyzing with
proper discernment the teachings one has heard and understood; the
adornment of not apprehending any phenomenon as a fixed referent, so as to
fully ripen all sentient beings;

the adornment of skillful means blessed by the awakening of the buddhas; and
the adornment of having attained dhāraṇī. These eight, then, constitute the
adornment of its merits and benefits.

This dhāraṇī should be kept constantly and continuously in mind. The
recollective meditation on the buddhas should be practiced. When these
foundations of the dhāraṇī are taken to heart, all karmic obscurations will be
completely purified. The meditative absorption (samādhi) called "Lotus Array"
will also be attained. All who are sick and afflicted should be touched with the
hand. The recitation, too, should be performed immeasurably.

Having spoken these words, the Blessed One concluded, and those great
bodhisattvas, those great śrāvakas, and the world together with its gods,
humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced, and they gave heartfelt praise to

what the Blessed One had taught.

The Dharma discourse of the dhāraṇī known as The Noble Buddha-Nature is complete.

Translated from the Sanskrit by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla together with the great editor-translator, the monk Ye shes sde, and then revised.

Translator's Notes

- The opening phrase "Dharma Categories of the Dhāraṇī" renders the compound dharma-viparyāya / धर्मविपर्याय, literally "synonym-categories of the Dharma," a standard genre designation indicating that what follows presents the topic under various enumerative headings or synonymous descriptions. The term is translated consistently as "Dharma Categories" throughout.

The setting description is unusually elaborate and somewhat elliptical in the Tibetan, with a long chain of qualifying phrases describing the location before the main verb. The translation resolves these as a series of appositive descriptions of the assembly place, which is the most natural reading.

The mantra at the close is left in its Sanskrit phonetic form as transmitted; the Tibetan reproduces a Sanskrit dhāraṇī and no translation of the mantra syllables is attempted, in keeping with tradition.

- The dhāraṇī syllables are transliterated from the Tibetan phonetic rendering; the Sanskrit reconstruction is approximate throughout, as dhāraṇī syllables in Tibetan transmission often represent degraded or variant Sanskrit forms. The transliteration follows the Tibetan closely while restoring standard Sanskrit phonology where the intent is reasonably clear.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, listing the eighth adornment incompletely; the translation renders exactly what is present and does not supply the missing items.

- The colophon names three collaborators on the Tibetan translation: the Indian paṇḍitas Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, and the senior Tibetan lotsāwa Ye shes sde, one of the most prolific translators of the early imperial period. The phrase rendered "great editor-translator" renders zhu chen gyi lo tsā ba, indicating Ye shes sde's role as chief revising translator rather than simply a scribe. The term "Lotus Array" for the samādhi name Padma rnam par bkod pa is a straightforward translation of the Sanskrit Padmavyūha.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of

spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.